

The Vital Few

Loud is not the same as big, and the Pareto chart is how you tell them apart.

Loudest, Not Biggest

A software company chased the angry, escalated complaints about the mobile app crashing. Engineers and sprints poured in, yet satisfaction barely moved. A Pareto chart showed crashes were only about eight percent of complaints. Billing confusion and slow response times made up well over half, but they were quiet, so they had been ignored.

The Vocabulary

The two or three tall bars on the left are the vital few, the small number of categories causing most of the problem. The long tail on the right is the trivial many, lots of categories that each cause only a little. With limited resources, which is always, you attack the vital few first.

An Honest Caution

Biggest is not automatically first. Sometimes the tallest bar is hugely expensive or politically impossible, while the second bar is cheap and easy. A smart improver weighs impact against effort. The Pareto does not make the decision, but it makes sure the decision is based on reality.

Remember this

Fixing the two biggest bars often does more than fixing the other ten combined.